

TB De-Esser

Version: 1.0.0 | Documentation date: 2026-08-12

Overview

Places abrasive S and SH sounds behind the performance while preserving diction, body, brightness, and air.

What this plug-in solves

Sibilance can jump out on a few consonants even when the performance changes from a whisper to a strong phrase. A static EQ darkens every word, while a conventional threshold can miss quiet fricatives or overreact to loud vowels. TB De-Esser follows the acoustic shape of sibilance instead of relying only on level, so musicians, producers, dialogue editors, and sound designers can calm distracting consonants without flattening the whole performance.

What you can expect

- S and SH sounds that sit behind the performance instead of piercing through it
- Clear diction, vocal body, brightness, and air that remain connected to the original voice
- A natural full-signal reduction option and a more selective sibilance-band option
- Stable mono or stereo processing with a linked image and repeatable preset recall

How it works

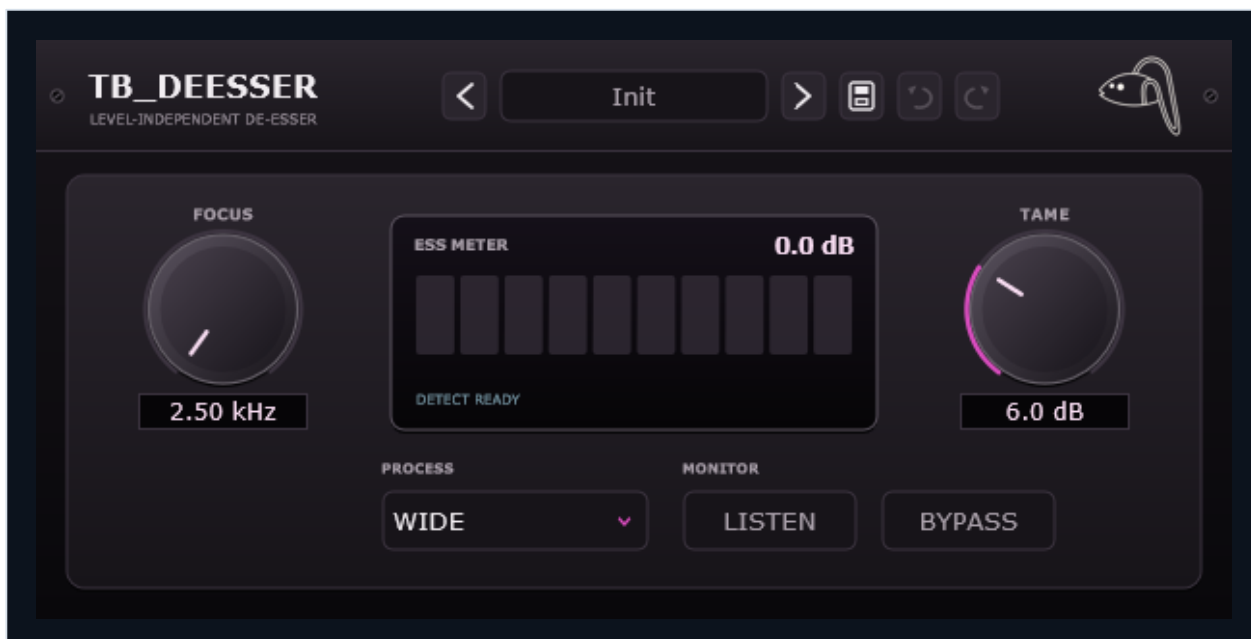
TB De-Esser looks for the changing texture that distinguishes abrasive frication from the surrounding voice. Because detection follows that texture rather than a fixed loudness threshold, quiet and loud consonants can be controlled by the same setting without turning every bright vowel into a trigger.

FOCUS tells the detector which part of the frication deserves the most attention, and TAME limits how far the sound can be pushed back. WIDE moves the whole performance together during a detected event, while SPLIT reduces only the selected harsh area. The stereo channels share the same decision so the image stays steady.

Quick start

- 1** Loop the phrase with the most distracting S or SH sound and begin with Init or the closest Factory preset.
- 2** Turn LISTEN on and move FOCUS until the harsh frication is easiest to hear in the monitored signal.
- 3** Turn LISTEN off and begin in WIDE so the voice moves naturally as one performance.
- 4** Raise TAME until the consonant settles behind the word without becoming dull, swallowed, or lisped.
- 5** Switch to SPLIT if WIDE makes the complete word or vocal level dip more than you want.
- 6** Watch ESS METER to confirm real reduction, then compare with BYPASS while the DAW's delay compensation remains enabled.
- 7** Check the full mix at a comfortable level and save a USER preset when the setting translates across several phrases.

Interface and key sections



This is a direct capture of the current plug-in interface. Use the visible labels to locate the areas and controls explained below.

FOCUS-guided detection

FOCUS moves the center of the detector's attention. It is not a simple high-pass filter, crossover, or permanent EQ point. Use LISTEN on the most abrasive consonant and move FOCUS until the monitored frication is clearest, then switch LISTEN off before judging the result.

WIDE and SPLIT processing

WIDE lowers the complete signal only while sibilance is detected. This usually feels cohesive and natural because the voice moves as one performance. SPLIT reduces the detected harsh band instead, preserving more body and overall level movement when WIDE sounds as though the whole voice is ducking.

ESS METER and DETECT status

ESS METER shows the gain reduction actually being applied, both as a number and as ten visual segments. DETECT READY means no confident sibilance is currently selected; DETECT followed by a percentage shows detector confidence. The percentage is not gain reduction and should not be used as a target score. ESS METER may correctly show no reduction while LISTEN or BYPASS is active.

Factory preset library

Factory presets are grouped by source and intention. VOCAL: Init, Gentle Vocal, Bright Vocal, Low Sibilance, Close Mic, Whisper Control, Strong Sibilance. CONTROL: Split Precision, Guitar Pick, Cymbal Edge. Use the closest preset as a starting direction, then retune FOCUS for the current recording.

Preset and edit header

Previous preset and Next preset move through Factory and saved USER presets; holding an arrow continues through the list. Save user preset stores the current state, while Undo and Redo step through parameter and preset changes. Clicking the preset name opens the VOCAL, CONTROL, and USER groups, and an edited setting is shown as Custom.

User preset library

Saved user presets are kept in the user's Documents/TB_DeEsser/Presets/User folder and use the .tbdeesser extension. A saved preset recalls FOCUS, TAME, the WIDE or SPLIT choice, LISTEN, and BYPASS. DAW sessions also restore the complete plug-in state. The plug-in does not provide preset rename or delete commands, so those file operations are handled outside the panel.

Mono, stereo, and session timing

The current plug-in package supports Windows x64 VST3 hosts and mono or stereo tracks. Stereo detection and reduction are linked so a sibilant event does not pull the image toward one side. Processing uses a fixed delay, so keep the DAW's delay compensation enabled and use the plug-in for editing, mixing, and post-production rather than low-latency live monitoring.

Purposefully simple control set

There are no separate Dry/Wet, Output, Threshold, Attack, Release, Ratio, external sidechain, MIDI, or M/S controls, and there is no quality or low-latency switch. TAME sets the reduction ceiling, FOCUS directs detection, WIDE or SPLIT chooses how the reduction is applied, and BYPASS provides the before-and-after comparison. All five host parameters, FOCUS, TAME, MODE, LISTEN, and BYPASS, can be automated.

Controllable properties

The guide uses the names shown on the plug-in panel. Each explanation describes the audible result, a useful way to approach the control, and an important interaction to listen for.

Control	What it does and when to use it
FOCUS	Moves the center of the detector's attention toward the part of the frication you want to control. It does not apply a permanent EQ curve to the voice. Turn LISTEN on, sweep FOCUS across the troublesome consonant, and stop where the abrasive frication is clearest. Turn LISTEN off before judging the voice.
TAME	Sets the maximum reduction allowed when sibilance is detected. It is a ceiling for intervention, not a threshold or constant cut. Raise it until the S or SH sound moves behind the word, then back it down if diction becomes dull, swallowed, or lisped.
MODE - WIDE / SPLIT	Chooses one of two reduction behaviors. WIDE moves the complete signal together during sibilance, while SPLIT reduces the detected harsh band and preserves more body and overall level movement. Start with WIDE for cohesive vocal movement. Choose SPLIT when body and overall level must stay steadier, then compare both choices on the same phrase.
LISTEN	Monitors the FOCUS-weighted candidate signal so the detector's target can be found quickly. It is a setup monitor, not the final processed sound. Use it only long enough to identify the detector target. Disable it before comparing, saving the final state, or exporting.
BYPASS	Returns the latency-aligned unprocessed signal for a direct before-and-after comparison. Keep DAW delay compensation active and compare the same short phrase so timing, not a shifted playback position, remains consistent.

ESS METER and DETECT status are visual feedback; the preset name and menu, Previous preset, Next preset, Save user preset, Undo, and Redo are panel commands. They are not separate automation rows, so their behavior is explained in the interface section.

Practical uses

Lead vocal with changing intensity

- Start with Gentle Vocal, Bright Vocal, or Strong Sibilance according to the recording.
- Use LISTEN to retune FOCUS on both a quiet and a strong consonant.
- Return to WIDE, raise TAME gradually, and check that vowels keep their brightness.
- Compare several phrases rather than perfecting only one isolated S sound.

Expected result: Harsh consonants move behind the lead while diction, body, and emotional level changes remain intact.

Breathy or whispered vocal

- Begin with Whisper Control and loop a phrase that contains both breath and sibilance.
- Use LISTEN to find the sharp frication without treating every breath as a problem.
- Try SPLIT and use only enough TAME to stop the consonant from masking the word.
- Check phrase endings, where breath and air should remain expressive.

Expected result: The whisper stays intimate and airy while the abrasive edge becomes easier to place in the mix.

Narration and dialogue cleanup

- Use Close Mic or Low Sibilance as a starting point and repeat the most distracting line.
- Tune FOCUS with LISTEN, then turn LISTEN off before judging intelligibility.
- Use WIDE for a cohesive spoken result or SPLIT when the entire word appears to dip.
- Check BYPASS at the same listening level across several speakers or headphones.

Expected result: Speech becomes less fatiguing without sounding dull, processed, or detached from the room.

Guitar pick or cymbal edge control

- Start with Guitar Pick or Cymbal Edge and loop the sharpest repeated event.
- Use LISTEN to place FOCUS on the edge rather than the musical body.
- Choose SPLIT when preserving the weight and sustain of the instrument is important.
- Raise TAME only until the repeated edge stops drawing attention.

Expected result: The sharp attack becomes easier to blend while the instrument keeps its weight, sustain, and placement.

Automation and preset handoff

- Build a stable setting across the representative phrases before writing automation.
- Automate any of the five host parameters only where the arrangement needs a clear change, with TAME and BYPASS usually providing the simplest moves.
- Save the final state as a USER preset and give it a source-specific name.
- Reload the preset and verify the WIDE or SPLIT choice, LISTEN state, and BYPASS state before export.

Expected result: The processing remains repeatable across sessions without leaving a monitoring or bypass state active by mistake.

Common pitfalls

If the voice becomes dark, swallowed, or lisped, TAME is too strong for that phrase or WIDE is moving too much of the signal. Lower TAME first, then compare WIDE and SPLIT on the same consonant until the word keeps its natural shape.

If obvious sibilance passes through, retune FOCUS with LISTEN before raising TAME further. Use LISTEN to find the detector target again; more TAME cannot help when FOCUS is aimed at the wrong part of the sound.

If the whole word or vocal appears to duck, switch from WIDE to SPLIT and compare again. Choose SPLIT, then readjust TAME because the selective mode may need a different reduction ceiling.

LISTEN is a temporary setup monitor and is intentionally thin or abrasive; turn it off for the processed result and before export. Disable LISTEN before saving the final preset or export state, then verify the complete vocal in context.

DETECT percentage reports detector confidence, while ESS METER reports the gain reduction that is actually heard. Judge the sound with ESS METER and your ears; a higher DETECT percentage is not automatically a better setting.

The plug-in uses a fixed processing delay, so keep DAW delay compensation enabled and do not treat it as a low-latency tracking processor. Use the plug-in on a compensated editing, mixing, or post-production path rather than a live low-latency monitor path.

The simple panel does not provide separate Dry/Wet, Output, Threshold, Attack, Release, Ratio, external sidechain, MIDI, M/S, or quality controls; use the available controls according to their defined roles. Do not search for hidden dynamics controls; retune FOCUS, choose WIDE or SPLIT, and set the required ceiling with TAME.